Ford Motor Company

James P. Vondale, Director
Automotive Safety Office
Environmental & Safety Engineering

March 2, 2001

Mr. Kenneth N. Weinstein
Associate Administrator for Safety Assurance
National Highway Traffic Safety Administration
400 Seventh Street, S.W.
Washington, D.C. 20590

Dear Mr. Weinstein:

Re: Ford Recall No. 01S08 – 2000-2001 Model Year Taurus/Sable Adjustable Pedal Stop Lamp Switch Grease Contamination

Summary

- Ford Action -- Ford is conducting a voluntary safety recall involving 2000-2001 model year Ford Taurus and Mercury Sable Passenger Cars equipped with adjustable pedals. These vehicles were built from May 1999 through August 2000.

- Number of Vehicles Involved -- Approximately 157,000 vehicles.

- Affect on Vehicle Operation – If the grease from the adjustable pedal assembly enters the stop lamp switch, it can contaminate the contacts, leading to carbon build up, and potentially, a short circuit. A short circuit could lead to either the brake lamps staying on, or to a loss of brake lamp function. Malfunctioning stop lamps could increase the risk of a vehicle crash.

- Service Procedure -- Dealers will replace the brake lamp switch and wipe down the adjustable pedal assembly to remove excess grease.

Attached is the detailed information required by the applicable portions of 49 CFR Part 573 -- Defect and Non-Compliance Information Report.

Sincerely,

James P. Vondale

Attachment
01S08 5d/rjw/ae/tab

ATTACHMENT

49 CFR Part 573 -- DEFECT INFORMATION REPORT
01S08 – 2000-2001 MODEL YEAR TAURUS/SABLE ADJUSTABLE PEDAL STOP LAMP SWITCH GREASE CONTAMINATION

Pursuant to Part 573 of Title 49 of the Code of Federal Regulations, Defect and Noncompliance Reports, Ford Motor Company submits the following information concerning a safety recall action that it is voluntarily initiating.

573.5 (c) (2) -- Potentially Affected Vehicles

Certain 2000-2001 model year Ford Taurus and Mercury Sable passenger cars with the adjustable pedal option and built at the Chicago and Atlanta Assembly Plants from May 3, 1999 through August 14, 2000 are potentially affected.

Because these vehicles are not produced in VIN order, information as to the applicability of this action to specific vehicles can best be obtained by either calling Ford's toll-free line (1-800-392-3673) or contacting a local Ford dealer, who can obtain specific information regarding the vehicles from the Ford On-line Automotive Service Information System (OASIS) database.

573.5 (c) (3) -- Estimated Population of Vehicles Potentially Affected

Approximately 157,000 vehicles.

573.5 (c) (4) -- Estimated Percentage of Affected Vehicles with the Defect Condition

Unknown.

573.5 (c) (5) --Description of the Defect

The adjustable pedal assembly on the subject vehicles may have excess grease that could potentially enter the stop lamp switch and contaminate the contacts. This could lead to a build up of carbon, and potentially, a short circuit. A short circuit could either cause the stop lamps to remain on, or to a loss of stop lamp function. Malfunctioning stop lamps could increase the risk of a vehicle crash.

Ford is aware of approximately 9,000 warranty reports on adjustable pedal vehicles for replacement of the stop lamp switch. A review of reports did not locate any that alleged that an accident or injury occurred.

573.5 (c) (6) -- Chronology of Events

Ford first became aware of this condition and began investigating it during the summer of 2000. The initial investigation determined that the adjustable pedal assemblies used a different, lower temperature grease than the fixed pedal assemblies. During August, 2000 the grease on the adjustable pedal assemblies was revised and an operation was added to wipe excess grease from the assemblies. Testing was initiated to establish the link between the grease and the malfunctioning stop lamp switches. In addition, field and warranty reports were monitored during late 2000 and early 2001 to establish whether the condition was a low mileage concern on a small number of vehicles, or whether the condition would continue to occur on additional vehicles built with the low temperature grease. Ford has recently concluded that there is evidence of a defect trend and on February 23, 2001 decided to take this action.

573.5 (c) (8) -- Service Program

Ford will notify owners of record of affected vehicles to return vehicles to dealers for replacement of the brake lamp switch and to have excess grease wiped off of the adjustable pedal assembly. This service will be performed at no charge to owners. Ford currently anticipates that owner notification will occur on or before the week of March 26, 2001.

573.5 (c) (9) -- Press statement and Dealer/Owner Letters

Ford does not plan to make a public statement concerning this action. Notices to dealers and owners from Ford Customer Service Division will be forwarded when available.

573.5 (c) (11) -- Recall Number

Ford has assigned recall number 01S08 to this action.